

THE FOUR VALUE MODES OF AI.

Which of the four quadrants does your product sit in — and how each one changes implementation effort, value proposition and rejection risk.

THE FOUR IMPLEMENTATION MODES

MODE 01

AMPLIFIER

Same person, much faster

MODE 02

SUBSTITUTE

AI executes, human supervises

MODE 03

JOB CREATOR

New profession enabled by AI

MODE 04

DEMOCRATISER

More people do what was once restricted

1 COMPARATIVE MATRIX BY DIMENSION

DIMENSION	AMPLIFIER	SUBSTITUTE	JOB CREATOR	DEMOCRATISER
CORE PROPOSITION	Existing person produces more in the same time	AI executes end-to-end process	AI enables a previously non-existent role	Access to capability once restricted to specialists
SALES EASE	Easy — company wants productivity without layoffs	Hard — full process redesign required	Medium — market category must mature	Medium — depends on mass adoption
IMPL. EFFORT	Low	Very high	Medium	High (scale)
INTERNAL RESISTANCE	Low — does not threaten jobs	High — replaces an existing function	Low — creates, does not eliminate	Medium — requires cultural shift
REAL EXAMPLE	AI in CRM: auto follow-up and notes for sales rep	100% AI-run customer service with human in loop	Agent ops specialist as a new role	Lovable / Vibe Code: anyone builds software
MAIN RISK	Under-use — user does not adopt the copilot	Process failure without redesign	Timing — market may not be ready	Quality — democratisation without curation

2 WHEN EACH MODE MAKES SENSE

AMPLIFIER

Client wants to keep the team and increase output. Lower political resistance and shorter sales cycle.

SUBSTITUTE

Function cost is high and process is documented. Requires executive sponsor and months of redesign.

JOB CREATOR

AI enables something previously impossible. Requires market education — adoption timing defines success.

DEMOCRATISER

Goal is scale of access. Requires a simple product, quality curation and effective onboarding.

3 COMMON PITFALLS BY MODE

Wrong mode, wrong client

Selling a substitute to a company that wants an amplifier. The client cancels when it realises the process needs redesign.

Democratiser without quality

Open product without curation generates poor outputs. Adoption grows but retention collapses when users see results.

Substitute without sponsor

IT builds without the business. After 3 months, commercial says "that's not it." Months of work discarded.

4 HOW TO CHOOSE — DECISION TREE

Is the target process documented with a measured KPI? No → safest entry point with least resistance.

AMPLIFIER

Does the client want to eliminate the human role and has an executive sponsor plus documented process?

SUBSTITUTE

Does AI enable a task that was previously impossible without a specialist, in a category with no competitor yet?

JOB CREATOR

Is the goal scale of access — more people doing what few could before, with a simple product?

DEMOCRATISER

The market no longer values headcount reduction on its own. The right question is: which of the four modes does your product move the client's needle — and do they know that before signing?